



Unstoppable duo: Lando Norris (right) and Oscar Piastri celebrate their 1-2 finish for McLaren in Austria.

GETTY IMAGES

eyes turned to the front, and Norris had only one goal in mind: keep Piastri behind. But it was easier said than done. The Australian's sudden bursts brought him agonisingly close to Norris — he even managed to nose ahead for a few seconds before being forced back behind. It was only a couple of weekends ago when the two were involved in a not-so-friendly fight, which resulted in Norris' retirement from the Canadian Grand Prix. The hard-core racing was once again a reminder of the infamous papaya rules that were sternly followed by the McLaren garage. The intra-team rivalry was only starting to break into the scene — one that the paddock had long been waiting for.

The last time a team had both its

contenders fighting for the prized position? Back in 2016, when an in-form Lewis Hamilton and a charging Nico Rosberg were at each other's throats for the title. The competitive spirit of both Mercedes drivers sometimes left a huge mess on the track, and an even bigger one within the garage.

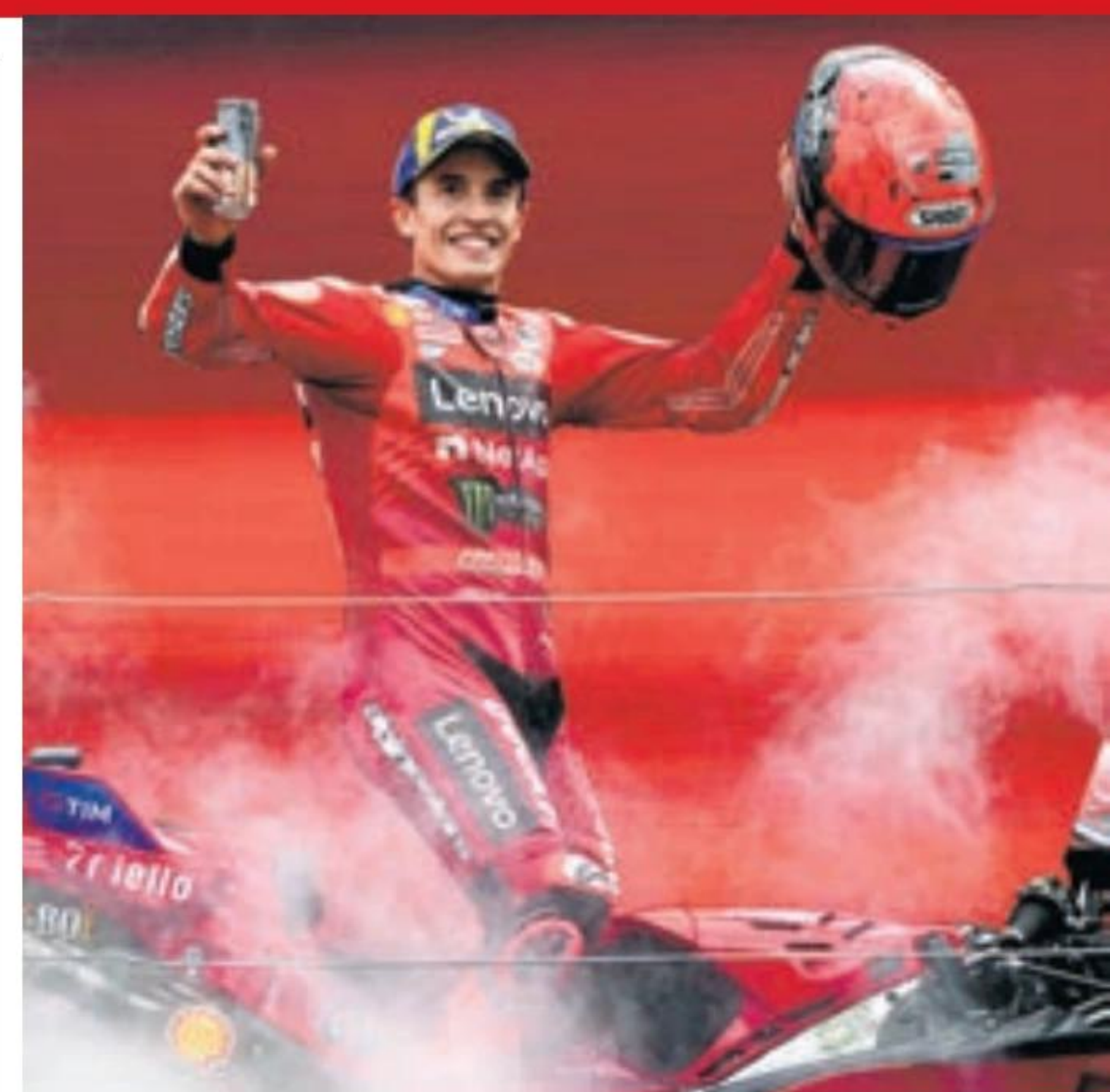
McLaren, to its credit, has so far handled this brewing rivalry with greater calm, but not without a few bumps along the way. A no-points show in Montreal threw the Briton off his catch-up game, once again having to start fresh. But if Canada showed the dangers of friendly fire, Austria was the perfect rebound for Norris.

The 25-year-old delivered a near-flawless drive, showcasing not only his skill but also his newfound ability to rebound under pressure. By stitching together the perfect weekend and executing a clean race, Norris is capable of staying in the hunt for his maiden championship — one he realises is more within reach.

But standing in his way is arguably the most formidable opponent he could have asked for — a teammate in the form of his life. The younger contender, Piastri, made use of the opportunity at hand to unleash his full potential and come into his own. The Australian was quicker to power ahead to five race victories and snatch the lead in the World Championship.

While his talent was never in question, it certainly was not how many — in fact, most in the Formula One paddock — expected the season to unravel, especially Norris. The 25-year-old could learn from his counterpart on staying composed and avoiding mistakes. A couple more races like Austria, and he could soon find himself becoming the frontrunner — a position he will need to learn to protect better.

It's become clear that in the current landscape, there's no one else capable of consistently challenging McLaren. The battle instead is internal, and as the championship wears on, the stakes will only grow. Norris' win in Austria was vital — a reminder to Piastri, who still enjoys a 15-point lead, and to the paddock, that he remains in the title conversation.



AP

MotoGP



There's no stopping Marc Marquez and his quest for a record-equalling seventh MotoGP world title.

The Ducati rider made it two wins from two successive weekends in Italy and the Netherlands, strengthening his grip at the top of the standings.

The Spaniard claimed the 93rd win of his career across all classes — matching his motorcycle number — at the Italian GP. He completed a perfect weekend in Italy, claiming pole, winning the sprint, securing his fifth race win this season, and his first at Mugello since 2014. He also broke teammate Francesco Bagnaia's three-race win streak at the Mugello circuit, his home track, and in Assen later on.

Marquez backed up the positive result with another clinical outing at the Dutch GP, extending his championship advantage to a commanding 68 points over his younger brother, Alex Marquez. His closest contender, Alex, suffered a race-ending crash that left him with a fractured hand. The 32-year-old also equalled Giacomo Agostini's 68 premier class victories.